sitting idle. Preparations were in full swing to strike at the Congress first and hard. But in keeping with the practice of the British Imperialists to give an air of constitutional legality to all their repressive and illegal acts against the Indian people, the Indian Government published a lengthy justificatory statement immediately following the ratification of the "Quit India" resolution by the All-India Congress Committee. This statement, referring to the Congress demand for the immediate withdrawal of British power from India, and the decision to start "a mass struggle on non-violent lines on the widest possible scale", declared that the Government "had been aware, too, for some days past of the dangerous preparations by the Congress party for unlawful, and in some cases violent, activities directed, among other things, to interruption of communications and public utility services, the organisation of strikes, tampering with the loyalty of Government servants, and interference with defence measures, including recruitment". In the view of the Government of India, so went on the statement,—a masterpiece of British hypocrisy—the acceptance of the Congress demand would mean not only the betrayal of "their responsibilities to the people of India" but must also "mean betrayal of the allies, whether in or outside India, the betrayal in particular of Russia and China, the betrayal of those ideals to which so much support has been given and is being given today from the true heart and mind of India...". The fact was however that the British Government, in preparing for the brutal suppression of the national will to freedom of the Indian people, was acting in total and cynical disregard of the principles of freedom so pompously enunciated in the Atlantic Charter by Churchill and the President of the United States.

The All-India Congress Committee concluded its session on Saturday night. In the early hours of the morning of Sunday, August 9th, the Indian Government struck. As Bombay's British Commissioner of Police came to arrest Mahatma Gandhi, he very typically asked for half an hour's grace to finish his morning prayers. Gandhi's last message was : we get our freedom or we die.

At the same time, the police were busy rounding up all the Congress leaders assembled in Bombay and elsewhere. In the course of a few hours, the entire Congress movement with its ramifications spread over the length and breadth of the country had become underground. The Churchill Amery and Company